PIA3123 Theories of Development — Week 1: Introduction to International Development

1. Course Framing: What We Are Actually Studying

Keywords: contested concept, interpretive pluralism, politics of development, no step-by-step guide, theory as lens

- This course is **not** a step-by-step guide to development, and **not** a survey of every development theory (slide 5).
- It instead asks two framing questions: what constitutes development, and how we should understand development issues and their politics (slide 5).
- Theories are therefore treated as **competing answers to the same questions**, not as a march of progress from wrong ideas to right ones.
- Lecture agenda (slide 3): what are we studying → course outline → assessment → what is development.
- Every theory is examined on three axes (course outline): its interpretation of development, its target beneficiaries, and its significance — what it means, who it is for, why it matters.
- Logistics: Fridays 0900–1150, Term A 2026/27; lecturer Francesca Chiu, office hours by appointment only, no Canvas messages (slides 1–2).
- → **Study cue:** whenever a new theory appears, ask immediately *who needs development, how should it happen, why is it important?* Those questions are the spine of the course.

2. Course Roadmap: The 13-Week Arc

Keywords: problem-solving sequence, paradigm families, cumulative structure, quiz checkpoints

- Each week supplies one **family of answers** to the three diagnostic questions; later weeks critique or supplement earlier ones (slides 6, 19).
- **W1** Introduction to International Development — what development is, why it is contested, the map of paradigms.
- **W2** The Making of Underdevelopment: Modernization and Dependency — the founding debate, Modernisation vs Dependency.
- **W3** The Market and the State: Neoliberalism and Developmental State — two rival institutional prescriptions.
- **W4** The Alternatives: Human Development and Sustainable Development — people-centred and future-centred challenges to growth-first thinking.
- **W5** Agents of Development — who delivers development (states, IFIs, NGOs, experts, communities).
- **W6** Quiz 1 (covers Weeks 2–5).

- **W7** Politics of Aid (donor–recipient relations, conditionality, neo-colonial critique). **W8** Gender and Development. **W9** Post-development — rejection of development as a Western-centric discourse.
- **W10** Reading Week. **W11** AI and the Future of International Development. **W12** Documentary Screening (basis of the reflection assignment). **W13** Quiz 2 (whole course).
- → **Structure:** Weeks 2–5 are the core theoretical canon; Weeks 7–9 are thematic extensions; Weeks 11–12 apply and extend. Quiz 1 is the *theory* quiz; Quiz 2 is the *synthesis* quiz.

3. Assessment Architecture

Keywords: participation, two quizzes, documentary reflection, weightings, dates

Four components totalling 100% (slides 7–10): Participation 20%; Quiz 1 30% (9 Oct 2026); Documentary Analysis and Reflection 20% (20 Nov 2026); Quiz 2 30% (27 Nov 2026).

3.1 Participation (20%)

Keywords: discussion, peer feedback, Weeks 2–13, not attendance

- Evaluated from **Weeks 2 to 13** on two components (slide 8): participation in lecture discussions, and the **calibre of feedback provided to fellow peers**. Merely attending does not earn high marks.

3.2 Quizzes (60% combined)

Keywords: short essay-style, closed-book, in-class, cumulative

- Both are **in-class**, **closed-book**, **short essay-style** (slide 10).
- **Quiz 1** (Week 6) covers **Weeks 2 to 5**; **Quiz 2** (Week 13) covers **the whole course** — so Week 1's framing stays examinable.
- → The essay format rewards *explanation and comparison*, not recall of reading minutiae (slide 11).

3.3 Documentary Analysis and Reflection (20%)

Keywords: Week 12 screening, in-class write-up, apply theory, critical reflection

- Screening in **Week 12**; analysis written **individually during the lecture** (slide 9).
- Requirements (slide 9): identify the **key development issues**; **apply relevant theories and concepts**; **critically reflect** on the documentary's perspectives and implications.
- → By Week 12 you must attach a named theory to an unfamiliar case quickly. The Section 8 grid is the toolkit.

4. Academic Integrity and the AI Rule

Keywords: Turnitin, no AI assistance, plagiarism, zero marks, disciplinary action

- AI tools may **not** be used in any capacity for any written assessment (slide 12) — including **research purposes**, **incorporating AI-generated ideas**, and **AI translation tools**.
- Submissions undergo **Turnitin** checks for AI-generated text; the penalty is **zero marks** and possible disciplinary action, treated as plagiarism.
- Plagiarism in any form (including self-plagiarism across courses) also receives zero. The Department encourages the **Harvard** referencing system; APA/Chicago permitted if used consistently.
- Etiquette: no mobile devices in class; laptops only for note-taking; email replies within 72 hours excluding weekends.

5. Study Strategy: What the Quizzes Reward

Keywords: understanding over memorisation, comparison table, apply to policy, relations between ideas

Explicit guidance from lecture and course outline (slide 11):

- The quiz assesses **understanding of main concepts and debates**, not memorisation of reading details; you must **explain main ideas in your own words** and recognise how different theories approach the same issue.
- Recommended method — build a **comparison table**, answering six questions for each theory:
    - How does it understand development **and underdevelopment**?
    - What are its **main assumptions**?
    - What **role** does it give to the state, markets, international organisations and other agents?
    - What **policies** might follow?
    - What are its **main criticisms**?
    - How does it **differ from the other approaches** studied?
- Apply theories to real policies — with the key warning: **do not assume one policy = one theory** (slide 11).
- *Example of the applied style:* if a country protects selected industries and directs investment toward strategic sectors, which approach explains this? (Answer: Developmental State — Section 8.4.)
- → "What does this theory say?" is only half the question. The other half is *why it says this, how it differs from others, and how it reads a real development policy.*

6. The Three Diagnostic Questions

Keywords: who needs development, how should it happen, why does it matter, target beneficiary, presuppositions

Three questions every development theory must answer (slides 15–17) — the analytical grid for the whole semester. The block opens with a **word-cloud activity** on what "development" brings to mind (slide 4) and closes with a paired exercise to write your own question about international development (slide 20) — both designed to surface assumptions you already hold.

6.1 Question 1 — Who Needs Development? (slide 15)

Keywords: target population, the undeveloped other, comparative framing, diagnosis

- Asks **who is the subject and beneficiary** of development; the answer implicitly names a **deficit** — a population defined by what it lacks.
- Presupposes a comparison: some other place is already "developed" and serves as the reference point.
- *Examples (slide 18):* non-Western traditional societies; Latin American peripheries; indebted post-socialist states; East Asian countries; vulnerable individuals; present and future generations; subaltern actors.
- → The *same* world contains all these answers at once — the disagreement is about **who is the problem case**, not about the facts.

6.2 Question 2 — How Should Development Happen? (slide 16)

Keywords: means, growth, equality, freedom, sustainability, contested prescription

- Asks about the **means and mechanism**: what must actually be done.
- Slide 16 stages four rival answers as a live vote, each seeding a paradigm family:
    - "It's all about **national economic growth**!" → growth-first, Modernisation lineage.
    - "Development is about **equality**!" → structural/redistributive, Dependency lineage.
    - "But how about **freedoms and human rights**?" → Human Development lineage.
    - "We must consider **sustainability**!" → Sustainable Development lineage.
- These imply different policies, different winners and losers, and different measures of success.
- → **The political core of development studies:** the choice of means is a distributional choice.

6.3 Question 3 — Why Is Development Important? (slide 17)

Keywords: justification, purpose, freedom from want, dignity, self-reliance, long-term survival

- Asks for the **justification** — what development is *for*, and why it is worth pursuing.
- Slide 18's answers span **civilisation and freedom from want**, **reduced surplus extraction**, **growth that works for the poor**, **global expansion and national pride**, **reaching the poorest and preventing "everyday" violence**, **long-term solutions for future generations**, and **de-centring power**.

- → Justification is what makes a theory persuasive. Two theories can prescribe similar policies for entirely different reasons — hence **one policy ≠ one theory**.

7. Each Answer Implies a Different Measure of Success

Keywords: metric, GDP, distribution, capabilities, intergenerational balance, evaluative stakes

The four answers on slide 16 double as four **measuring sticks** — a theory's metric reveals what it really values.

- **Growth** → GDP/GNP; prescribe industrialisation and investment (Modernisation, 8.1).
- **Equality** → distribution; prescribe equal trade and reduced surplus extraction (Dependency, 8.2).
- **Freedom** → capabilities and choice; prescribe meeting human needs (Human Development, 8.5).
- **Sustainability** → intergenerational balance; prescribe long-term planning (Sustainable Development, 8.6).
- → Because metrics decide who counts as a success, each *how* smuggles in a different *why* — theory choice is never purely technical.

8. The Seven Paradigms at a Glance (slide 18)

Keywords: comparative grid, paradigm families, course map, who/how/why

Slide 18 presents the course's master grid: seven paradigms, each answering **who needs development**, **how should it happen**, and **what is the importance**. This is the single most exam-relevant slide of Week 1 — Quiz 1 covers Weeks 2–5, and every one of these paradigms recurs.

8.1 Modernisation

Keywords: non-Western societies, mutually supportive arenas, foreign assistance, civilisation, material want

- **Who needs development:** traditional, un-industrialised societies — i.e. **non-Western countries**.
- **How:** modernise across **mutually supportive arenas**; rely on **foreign assistance**.
- **Why/importance:** a route to **civilisation** and **freedom from material want**.
- *Example:* Rostow 1960's stages-of-growth model — any country could "take off" to self-sustaining growth if obstacles to modern business practice were overcome (Levitt 2021).
- → Key presupposition: development is a **universal linear path** that latecomers travel, with the West as the destination.

8.2 Dependency

Keywords: periphery, unequal exchange, technology transfer, surplus extraction, self-reliance

- **Who needs development: peripheral countries** — *Example:* Latin America.
- **How: equal trade relations**, **technology transfer**, and transformed **class relations**.
- **Why/importance: reduce surplus extraction and structural inequality**; achieve **self-reliance**.
- → Key move: underdevelopment is **not** an original condition to be outgrown but a **product of the same global process** that produced development elsewhere. Directly opposed to Modernisation's premise.

8.3 Neoliberalism

Keywords: structural adjustment, privatisation, deregulation, good governance, social capital, residual poverty

- **Who needs development: indebted and post-socialist states/countries reeling from structural adjustment**.
- **How: privatisation**; **free markets**; **financial deregulation**; **marketisation/controlled liberalisation**; **good governance**; **social capital**.
- **Why/importance: spur growth** and **promote individualism / make globalisation work for the poor**; **end residual poverty**.
- → Note **"residual"** poverty: the market is the presumed engine, and poverty is what remains for policy to mop up.

8.4 Developmental State

Keywords: East Asia, corporatism, entrepreneurial bureaucracy, export promotion, national pride

- **Who needs development: East Asian countries**.
- **How: corporatism**; **entrepreneurial bureaucracy**; **export promotion**.
- **Why/importance: expand into the global economy**; **preserve national pride**.
- → Explains the applied puzzle in Section 5: state direction of investment into strategic sectors while remaining export-oriented. Contrast with Neoliberalism — both embrace global markets, but only one makes the state entrepreneurial.

8.5 Human Development

Keywords: vulnerable individuals, human needs, holistic measures, everyday violence, freedom to choose

- **Who needs development: vulnerable and marginalised individuals** — note the shift of unit from *country* to *person*.
- **How: meeting human needs**; use **better, more holistic measures** of development (not GDP alone).

- **Why/importance: reach the poorest in society**; prevent **"everyday" violence** from being done; **freedom to pursue own choices**.
- → The "everyday violence" phrasing flags that deprivation is experienced continuously, not only in crises.

8.6 Sustainable Development

Keywords: current and future generations, growth vs degradation, long-term planning, mankind and environment

- **Who needs development: both the current and future generations** — the only paradigm that extends its constituency beyond the present.
- **How: strike a balance between growth and environmental degradation**; **long-term planning**; consideration of **both mankind and the environment**.
- **Why/importance:** a **future-oriented approach seeking long-term solutions**.
- → Unique move: it makes the **unborn** a stakeholder, which structurally limits present-day extraction.

8.7 Post-development

Keywords: subaltern actors, intellectual autonomy, grassroots mobilisation, rejection of modernity, de-centre power

- **Who needs development: subaltern actors** — *but also* **"the developed" themselves** (i.e. the paradigm refuses to treat development as a one-way lesson).
- **How: intellectual autonomy**; **local community empowerment**; **grassroots mobilisation**; **rejection of modernity** (as a Western-centric discourse).
- **Why/importance: avoid failures and homogenisation** of universal missions; **de-centre power**; a **participatory** approach to societal change.
- → Unlike the other six, this paradigm rejects the development project's own terms. It is the course's Week 9 destination, but it is flagged here at the start.

9. Reading the Grid: How to Use Slide 18

Keywords: comparison, cross-cutting patterns, policy implications, exam technique

- The grid is a **comparison device** — the kind the study-strategy guidance recommends building (slide 11; course outline).
- **Pattern 1 — the unit of concern shifts:** country (Modernisation, Dependency, Developmental State) → individual (Human Development) → generations (Sustainable Development) → actors within and beyond the "developed" (Post-development).
- **Pattern 2 — the state's role inverts:** entrepreneurial under the Developmental State; shrunk under Neoliberalism; ambivalent or suspect under Dependency and Post-development.
- **Pattern 3 — different theories, shared policy:** export promotion in both Developmental State and Neoliberal practice; redistributive language in both Dependency and Human Development — hence **one policy ≠ one theory**.

- → **Exam technique:** for any given policy, ask which *diagnosis* it presupposes before naming the paradigm. Naming the theory is half the mark; explaining how its presuppositions produce that policy is the other half.

10. Conclusion: The Two-Pronged Claim (slides 21–22)

Keywords: presupposition, comparative framing, corrigible flaws, revisable concept, theories and practices

The lecture closes with a two-part argument about what the concept of development *does*.

10.1 Prong 1 — Naming a Population "In Need" Is Never Neutral (slide 21)

Keywords: development exists elsewhere, causal account, comparative, diagnostic

- Identifying a population as in need of development **assumes two things**: that **development exists elsewhere** (the concept is inherently **comparative**), and that there is **some understanding of what caused that condition** (the label is also **causal**, carrying an implicit aetiology of poverty).
- → Disputes about who is "developing" are therefore also disputes about **the cause** of their condition, and thus about who bears responsibility for it.

10.2 Prong 2 — The Concept of the "Developed" Is Revisable (slide 21)

Keywords: social faults, correctable flaws, altered standard, normative opening

- Identifying social faults and inequalities and **viewing them as flaws that can be corrected** means the concept of what it means to be developed **can be altered**.
- → Development is **not a fixed yardstick** but a political and moral achievement that can be redefined — the opening that lets Human Development, Sustainable Development and Post-development claim the word for projects the classical paradigms would not recognise.

10.3 What Development Studies Is (slide 22)

Keywords: theories and discourses, practices and policies, Kothari, political implications

- Kothari 2019: development studies encompass a combination of theories or discourses, as well as practices and policies (slide 22).
- The field is **two-sided**: a body of theory **and** an apparatus of institutions, programmes and interventions.
- Closing question to the class: **how should we conceptualise development, and what political actions or interventions does this perspective imply?**
- → Every conceptualisation has a **policy entailment** — choosing a definition of development is choosing a politics.

11. Origins of the Development Agenda (Week 1 Essential Readings)

Keywords: decolonisation, Bandung 1955, UNCTAD 1964, NIEO, neoliberal turn, Kothari's critique

Context from the Week 1 essential readings (Kothari 2019; Levitt 2021) — part of two recommended textbooks plus essential and supplementary chapters, available through the CityU library (slide 13).

- Levitt 2021: the agenda came onto the table **before** the end of World War II, in anticipation of **decolonisation in Asia and Africa** — not in 1945 alone. Its founding literature came from independent-minded scholars across many countries — an international origin, later narrowed.
- Post-1945 the US priority was the **threat of communism**; a secondary aim was dissolving British and French preferential economic spheres.
- Counter-currents: **Bandung 1955** (Sukarno, Nehru, Nasser, Nkrumah) organised Asian–African **non-aligned** states against both Moscow and Washington; **UNCTAD** (1964, under Raúl Prebisch); the UN's **New International Economic Order** in the 1970s, to which the North conceded nothing meaningful.
- 1950s institutionalisation: the US State Department engaged leading universities to design development programmes (India → Harvard; Indonesia → MIT; Latin America → Chicago). Modernisation was the payoff — Rostow 1960's *Stages of Economic Growth*, subtitled *A Non-Communist Manifesto*, dominated political science and sociology.
- **The turn (1979–80):** Thatcher and Reagan restored "the discipline of capital over labour" and cut back government in the developing world; a "doctrinal coup" at the World Bank dismissed the economists behind the **basic needs** approach and installed neoliberals. Southern industrialisation — which had matched industrialised-country growth rates in 1950–1980 — was reclassified as inefficient, and the founders of development economics were demonised as structuralist.
- → **Kothari's argument:** the standard periodisation (growth/modernisation → underdevelopment → neoliberalism/Washington Consensus, anchored on 1945) obscures a **longer genealogy**, hiding both continuities with colonialism and the critical discourses written out of mainstream accounts (Marxist, post-colonial, feminist).
- *Exam value:* Kothari 2019 supplies Week 1's definition of development studies and the critique of how the field tells its history; Levitt 2021 shows development was **contested and politically driven from the outset**, never neutral and technical.

12. Key Terms and One-Liners

Keywords: definitions, quick recall, exam revision

- **Three diagnostic questions:** who needs development; how should it happen; why is it important (slides 15–17).

- **Development studies:** a combination of theories or discourses, as well as practices and policies (Kothari 2019).
- **The seven paradigms:** Modernisation, Dependency, Neoliberalism, Developmental State, Human Development, Sustainable Development, Post-development (slide 18).
- **One-liners:** *naming a population as "in need of development" is a comparative and causal claim, not a neutral description* (slide 21); *the paradigms disagree less about the facts than about who counts, who decides, and who pays*; *know what problem each theory solves and what problem it leaves behind.*

13. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, three questions, seven paradigms, assessment, study method

1. **Course aim:** not a step-by-step guide or a survey of every theory — it asks what constitutes development, and how we should understand development issues and their politics (slide 5).
2. **Three diagnostic questions** (slides 15–17): **who** needs development; **how** should it happen; **why** is it important. Every theory answers all three; every exam answer should too.
3. **Slide 16's four rival answers:** growth / equality / freedoms and human rights / sustainability — each seeding a paradigm family, and each implying a different **measure** of success (GDP / distribution / capabilities / intergenerational balance).
4. **Slide 18 grid — seven paradigms (who → how → why):** Modernisation (non-Western; reform across mutually supportive arenas + foreign assistance; civilisation, freedom from want) → Dependency (periphery; equal trade, technology transfer, class relations; self-reliance) → Neoliberalism (indebted/post-socialist; privatisation, free markets, deregulation, good governance, social capital; end residual poverty) → Developmental State (East Asia; corporatism, entrepreneurial bureaucracy, export promotion; national pride) → Human Development (vulnerable individuals; human needs, holistic measures; freedom to choose) → Sustainable Development (present **and** future generations; balance growth with degradation; long-term solutions) → Post-development (subaltern actors; intellectual autonomy, grassroots mobilisation, rejection of modernity; de-centre power).
5. **Cross-cutting patterns:** unit of concern shifts country → individual → generations; the state's role inverts; the same policy can belong to different theories — **one policy ≠ one theory**.
6. **Conclusion prong 1 (slide 21):** calling a population "in need of development" assumes development exists elsewhere **and** carries an implicit causal account of their condition.
7. **Conclusion prong 2 (slide 21):** treating social faults as **correctable flaws** means the standard of what counts as "developed" can be **altered** — the concept is revisable.
8. **Development studies (slide 22, Kothari 2019):** theories/discourses **plus** practices and policies. Every conceptualisation carries a **policy and political entailment**.
9. **Historical frame (Levitt 2021):** the agenda predates 1945, driven by decolonisation and Cold War politics; Bandung 1955, UNCTAD 1964, the NIEO; the neoliberal turn of

1979–80 recast the field. Kothari 2019 rejects the standard periodisation for a longer, more critical genealogy.

10. **Assessment:** Participation 20% (Weeks 2–13); Quiz 1 30% (9 Oct, Weeks 2–5); Documentary Analysis and Reflection 20% (20 Nov, written in the Week 12 lecture); Quiz 2 30% (27 Nov, whole course). Closed-book short essays; no AI; Harvard referencing.
11. **Study method:** build a comparison table on the six outline questions (development/underdevelopment; assumptions; role of state, markets, IOs, agents; resulting policies; criticisms; differences from other theories); apply theories to real cases.
12. **Next week (slide 23):** Modernization and Dependency — Rostow 1990 (*The Stages of Economic Growth*), Frank 2010 ("The Development of Underdevelopment"); supplementary Kvangraven 2021.